

**Time:** 5 minutes**Outcome:** Determine equilibrium, shortages, surpluses, adjustment, and comparative statics.**Difficulty:** ●●○ Intermediate

Shortages and Surpluses



THE CORE IDEA

A shortage occurs when quantity demanded exceeds quantity supplied at the current price. Buyers competing for limited supply put upward pressure on price. A surplus occurs when quantity supplied exceeds quantity demanded; sellers then face pressure to lower price. Adjustment tends toward the price where the two quantities are equal.



HOW TO RECOGNIZE IT

- At \$2 per gallon, buyers want 200 thousand gallons while sellers offer 100 thousand: a shortage.
- Above equilibrium, quantity supplied exceeds quantity demanded: a surplus.
- Compare quantities at the same price, then identify the pressure on price.

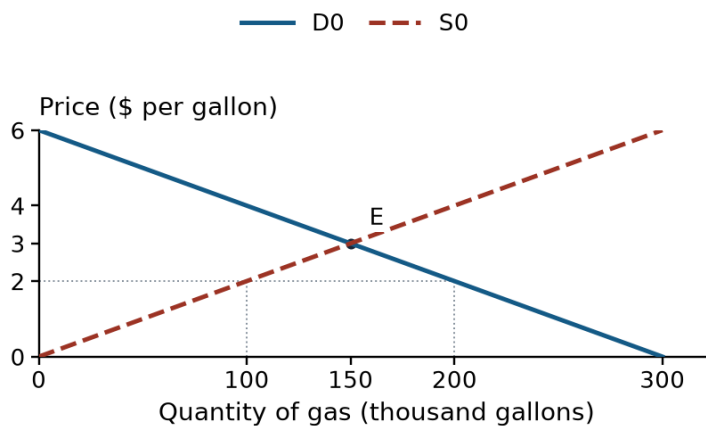


WATCH OUT

A common mistake is to reverse shortage and price pressure. Quantity demanded exceeds quantity supplied, so there is a shortage. Shortages push price upward.



WORKED EXAMPLE: MEASURING A SHORTAGE



At a price of \$2 per gallon, the graph shows quantity demanded of 200 thousand gallons and quantity supplied of 100 thousand. Because buyers want 100 thousand more gallons than sellers offer, the market has a shortage of $200 - 100 = 100$ thousand gallons. Upward pressure on price follows.



CHECK YOURSELF

At a price of \$4, buyers want 100 thousand gallons and sellers offer 200 thousand. Calculate the imbalance and predict the pressure on price.

**READY?**

Return to the game and master this concept.